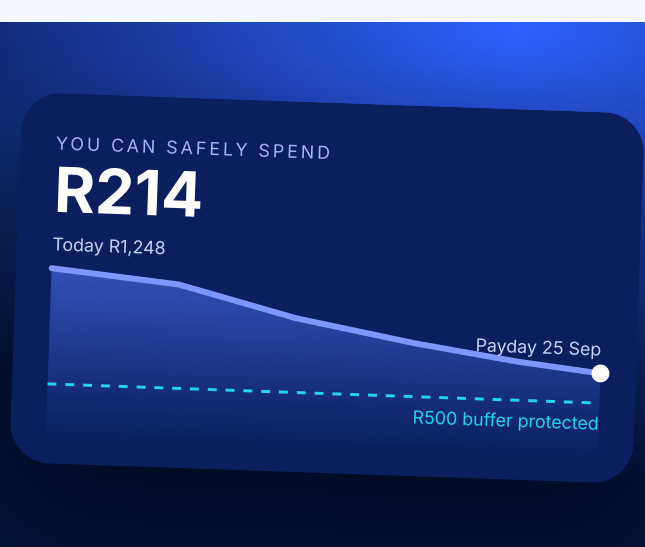
UX CASE STUDY · FINTECH · YOUTH BANKING

RISE

Real Income, Steady Earnings



Youth unemployment in South Africa has climbed for a decade, from 36.9% in 2015 to 47.4% by Q2 2026. This study explores the other side of that statistic: not the job search, but the first few months of being paid.

First-job earners · Buffer-first banking · Predictive warnings

ROLE	DESIGNER	SCOPE	STATUS
Individual contributor, UX Designer	Stanslous Nhau	Research → strategy → hi-fi UI	Design exploration, not built or shipped

This case study covers

- ✓ Problem
- ✓ Research method & thinking
- ✓ Synthesis & insights
- ✓ Collaboration & influence
- ✓ Design direction
- ✓ Solution & design decisions
- ✓ Success & impact
- ✓ Lessons learned & next steps

> Single contributor: I took RISE from research to hi-fi screens on my own.

CHAPTER 01 OF 08

01 Problem

01 · PROBLEM

Getting the job doesn't end the pressure, it changes its shape.

PROBLEM STATEMENT

Young South Africans who land a first job still feel under pressure: payday arrives, family obligations claim a fixed share, and little or no buffer remains. Existing youth accounts show what happened, not what happens next, and shame stops people asking for help. Without a safety net, the same cycle repeats every month.

How might we protect a first-job earner's breathing room between paydays, without shame or jargon?

CHAPTER 02 OF 08

02 Research method & thinking

02 · RESEARCH METHOD & THINKING

Three independent signals point the same way: structural, not just mindset.

I chose statistics that test three different explanations for the same behaviour. If young people were simply "bad with money", one would be weak and the others fine. All three came back low.

Secondary research · Three signals, three hypotheses · Composite persona · Loop mapping

1. **The emotional state** — 75% of South Africans under 35 report financial anxiety or stress, up 18% year-on-year.
   Source: Debt Rescue Money Stress Tracker, 2026
2. **The skills gap** — 39% feel confident in their own digital financial skills.
   Source: SA Social Media Landscape report
3. **The outlook** — 50%+ say they don't know how to build a stable financial future.
   Source: Old Mutual Youth Generational Wealth Survey

So what: three angles on one population move "maybe it's a mindset problem" toward "this looks structural". Skills and outlook are self-reported, so income and cost-of-living data would strengthen the case.

CHAPTER 03 OF 08

03 Synthesis & insights

03 · SYNTHESIS & INSIGHTS

Thabo doesn't need a feature-rich banking app; he needs to know he'll still be okay.

Thabo Mahlangu

The Cautious Provider

23 · Johannesburg · First job · R6,800/month

"If I spend this now, will I still be okay later?"

CORE NEED
Financial breathing room: keeping his buffer above zero.

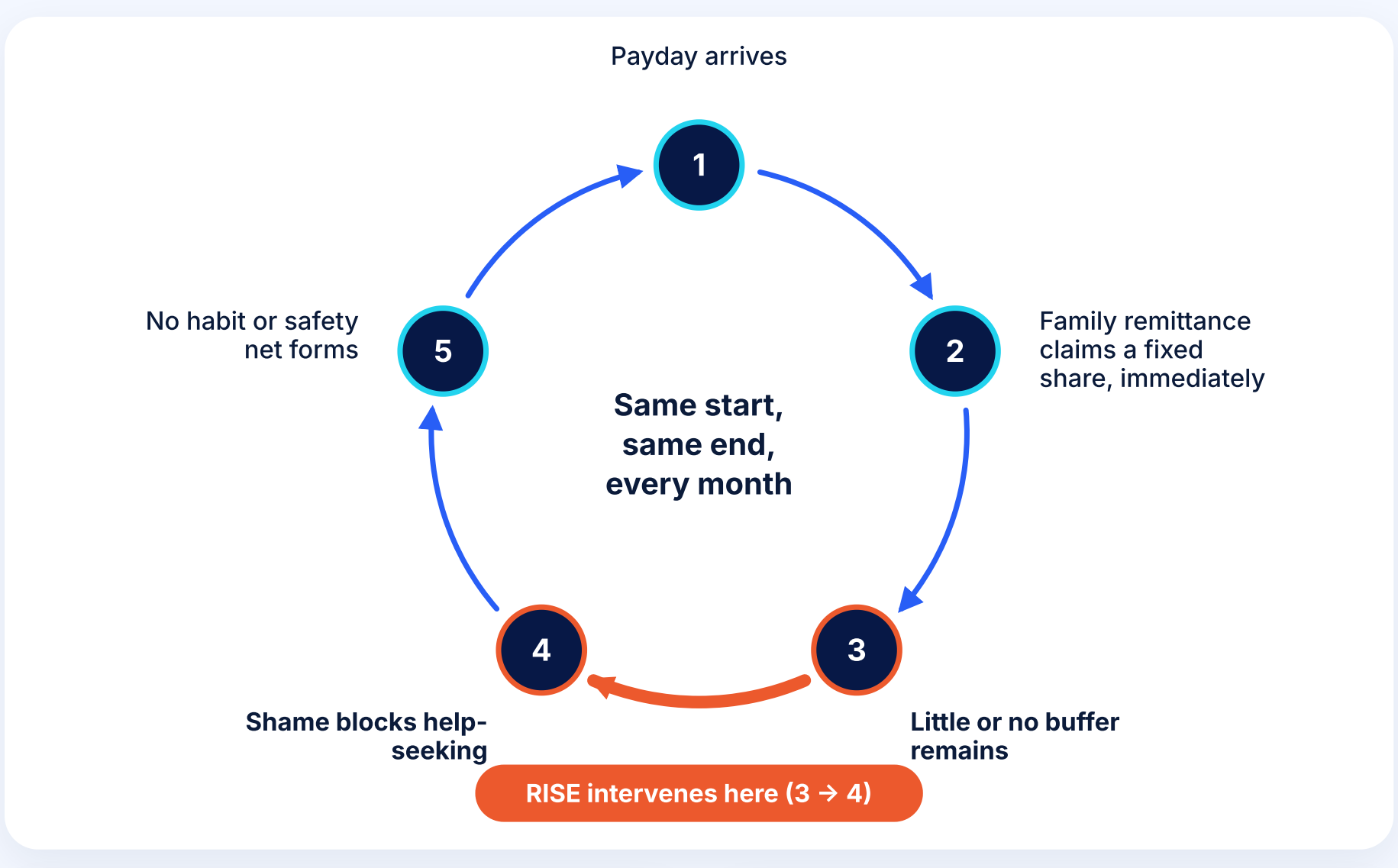
BEHAVIOURS
- Checks balance after payday, debit orders and larger purchases
- Always asks: "What will I have left after this?"

DECISION-MAKING
- Splits money into transport, home, food and "do not touch"
- Prefers reversible moves over locked commitments

FRUSTRATIONS
- Banks show what happened, not what happens next
- Jargon makes him feel judged
- Surprise deductions break his sense of control

MOTIVATIONS
- Support home without losing progress
- Build credit without debt anxiety
- End the month with money remaining

The insight: a loop, and only one point in it is designable


Payday arrives
1
2
Family remittance claims a fixed share, immediately
3
Little or no buffer remains
4
Shame blocks help-seeking
5
No habit or safety net forms
Same start, same end, every month
RISE intervenes here (3 → 4)

1. **Why a loop, not a journey**
   A linear journey can't explain why the same problem returns every month. Identical starting conditions give identical outcomes unless something inside the loop changes.
2. **One point in five is designable**
   RISE can't change what family expects or when payroll runs. It can make checking in on money private and judgment-free, so shame doesn't get the final word.

> Product implication: prioritise safe-to-spend, upcoming deductions and buffer warnings. Design for pressure moments, not only account management.

The loop is a working hypothesis from secondary research. Family remittance needs validating in interviews.

CHAPTER 04 OF 08

04 Collaboration & influence

04 · COLLABORATION & INFLUENCE

A buffer-first product only ships if other teams believe in it.

RISE was self-directed, so there were no stakeholders to negotiate with. Here is who I'd bring in, and how.

PARTNER	WHAT I'D NEED FROM THEM	HOW I'D EARN THEIR SUPPORT
Compliance & risk	Context-first onboarding must still meet KYC: defer fields, don't remove them	Show the staged sequence and where each legal check lands
Data & engineering	Reliable projections from income date and upcoming debits for the predictive warning	Prototype the warning with realistic numbers and agree an acceptable false-alert rate
Support & operations	A human escalation path behind Ask RISE	Map suggested prompts to the top support reasons
Product & business leads	Buy-in for a buffer-first metric over sign-ups	Lead with the loop and the north star: buffer above R0

> Influence comes from a clear problem, a testable metric and a prototype people can react to.

RISE was a solo exploration, so this is my plan, not a record of stakeholder sessions.

CHAPTER 05 OF 08

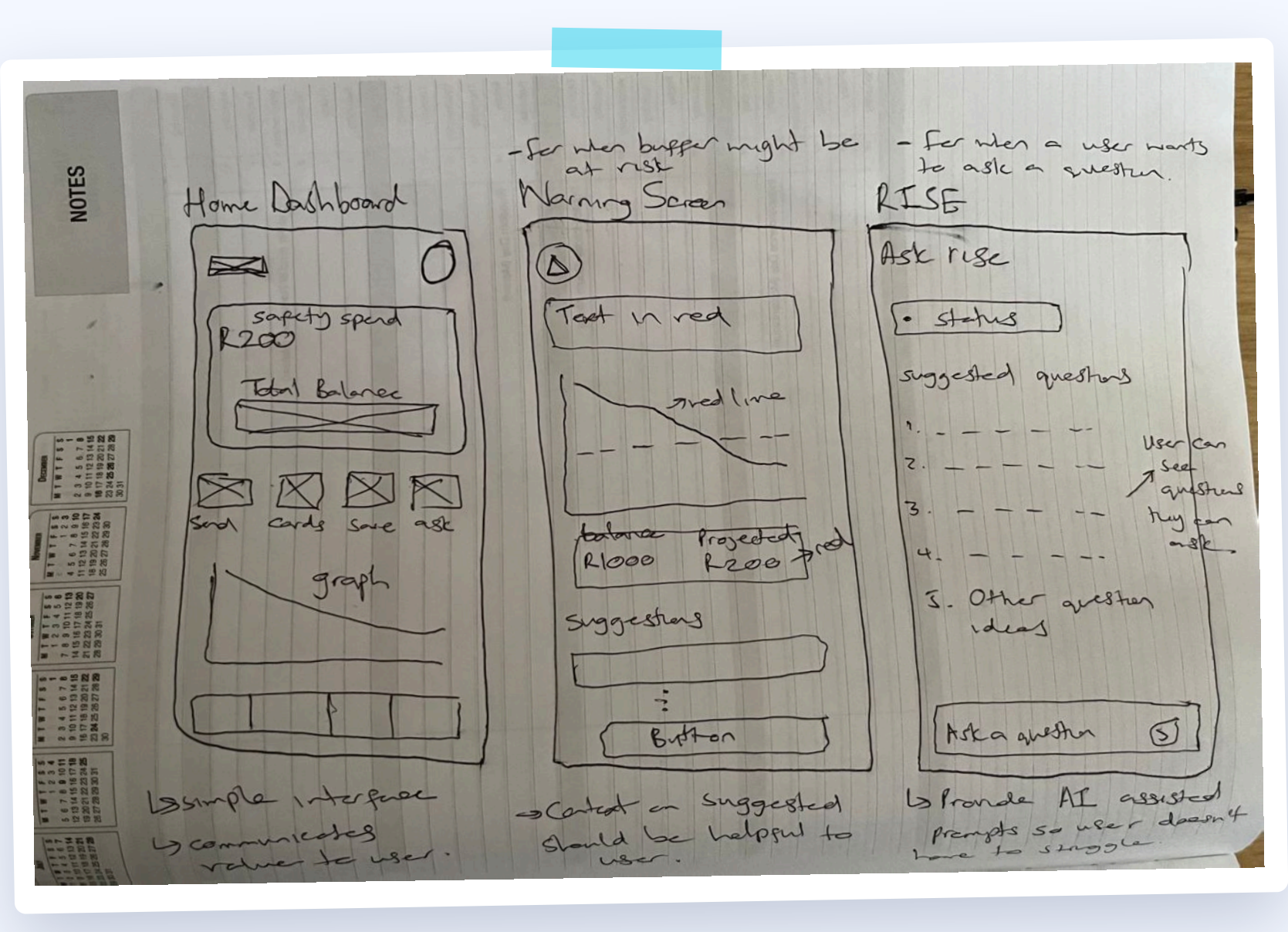
05 Design direction

05 · DESIGN DIRECTION

Calm, shame-free, and built for pressure moments.

1. **Design for pressure moments**
   Warn and guide when money is tight, not only when someone opens an account.
2. **Protect before you grow**
   Separate money that protects stability from money that funds ambition.
3. **Ask without shame**
   Suggested prompts so nobody starts from a blank screen or needs the right jargon.
4. **Colour carries meaning**
   Blue for action, orange for obligations, red for risk, green for progress.

From sketch to screen


NOTES
Home Dashboard
safety spend
R200
Total Balance
Send
Cards
Save
Ask
graph
↳ simple interface
↳ communicates value to user
- for when buffer might be at risk
Warning Screen
Text in red
red line
balance R1000
Projected R200
Projected
Suggestions
Button
→ Context on suggested should be helpful to user
- for when a user wants to ask a question
RISE
Ask rise
Status
Suggested questions
5. Other question ideas
User can see questions they can ask
Ask a question
↳ Provide AI assisted prompts so user doesn't have to struggle

1. **Home dashboard**
   A simple interface that communicates value to the user straight away.
2. **Warning screen**
   For when the buffer might be at risk: red text, a red projection line, balance against projected balance.
3. **Ask RISE**
   Suggested questions plus "other question". AI-assisted prompts so the user doesn't have to struggle.

Design system

- 🟦 Core Blue #285EF6 Actions
- Deep Navy #071846 Guidance
- 🟧 Obligation Orange #EC592D Required costs
- 🟥 Risk Red #F14A46 Warnings
- 🟩 Safety Green #008200 Progress
- Ink #111111 Text
- Sky Tint #EEF4FF Calm surfaces
- State Grey #5A5A5A Supporting text

TYPE SCALE · BASE 16, RATIO 1.25
H1 60 · H2 39 · H4 31
Heading 24 · Body 20 · Label 16

RADIUS
xs 4 · sm 8 · md 12 · lg 16
Primary and disabled button states

CHAPTER 06 OF 08

06 Solution & design decisions

06 · SOLUTION & DESIGN DECISIONS

Five decisions, each replacing a banking convention.

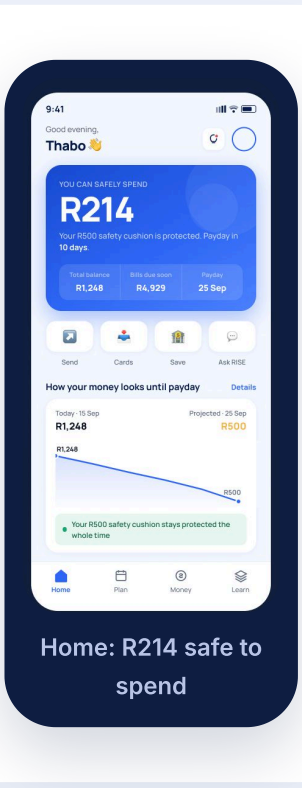
#	DECISION	BARRIER IT ADDRESSES	CONVENTION REJECTED
1	Buffer as a first-class object	Falling below zero with no protected money	A buffer treated as one more savings goal
2	Ask RISE quick-question channel	Embarrassment blocks help-seeking	FAQ, hidden chatbot or support ticketing
3	Money 101 progressive lessons	Jargon; not knowing what to learn	A standalone financial literacy hub
4	Context-first onboarding	Income alone doesn't show life stage	KYC-first, compliance-heavy sequence
5	Predictive buffer warning	Alerts arrive after the damage is done	Fixed-threshold low-balance alert

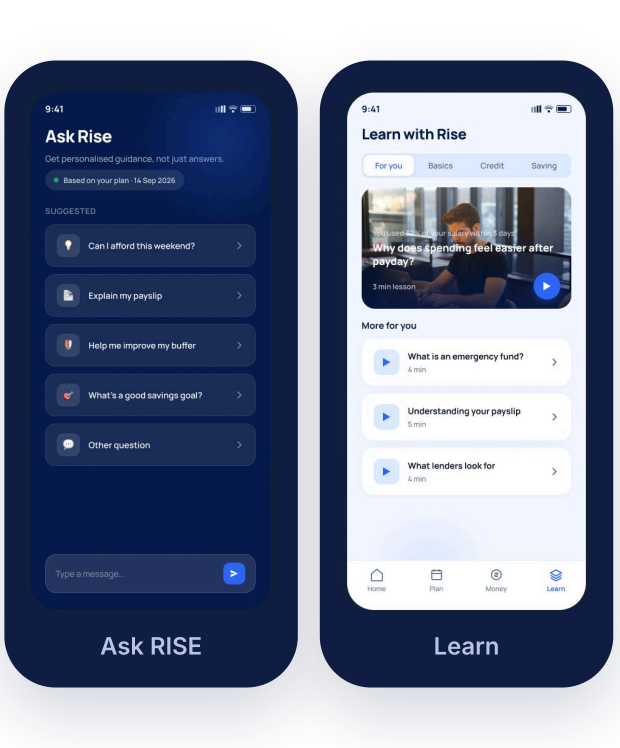
1 · Make the Buffer a first-class object

DECISION: The Buffer is surfaced in onboarding and throughout as money that protects Thabo from falling below zero.

WHY: His progress isn't wealth yet; it's surviving the month with something left.

REJECTED: A buffer beside a phone or holiday goal. It would make a safety mechanism compete with aspirations.





2 · Ask RISE, not a support ticket

DECISION: A clear place to ask money questions, with suggested prompts.

WHY: Embarrassment stops people asking at all (loop point 4).

REJECTED: An FAQ, hidden chatbot or ticketing flow.

3 · Money 101, not a wall of terms

DECISION: Short lessons beside everyday banking.

WHY: Education works best near the moment of uncertainty (loop point 5).

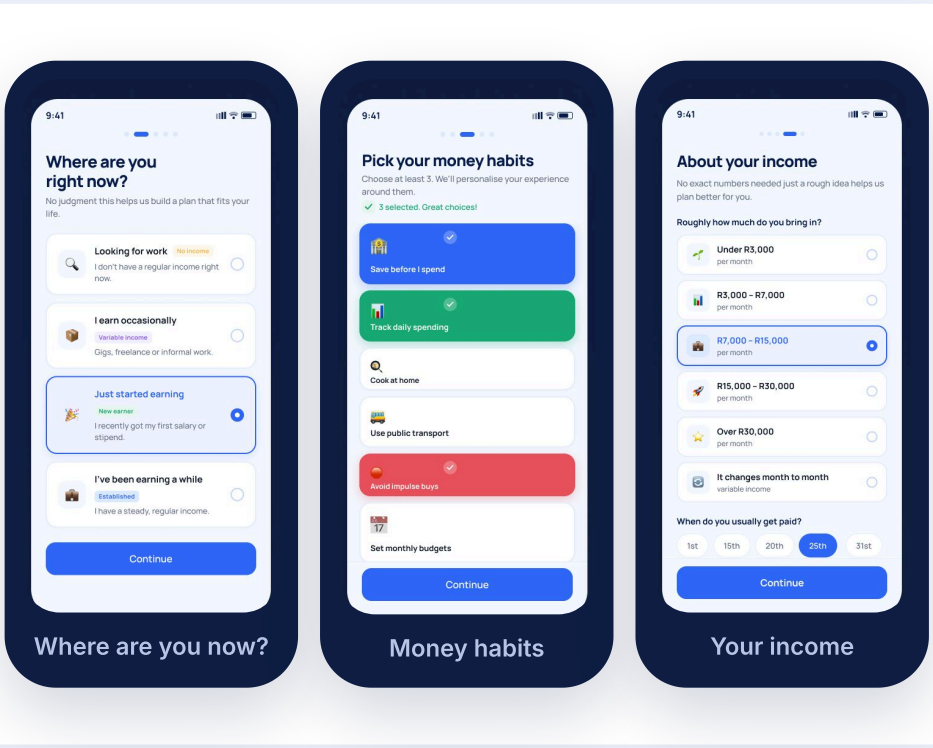
REJECTED: A literacy hub of articles and definitions.

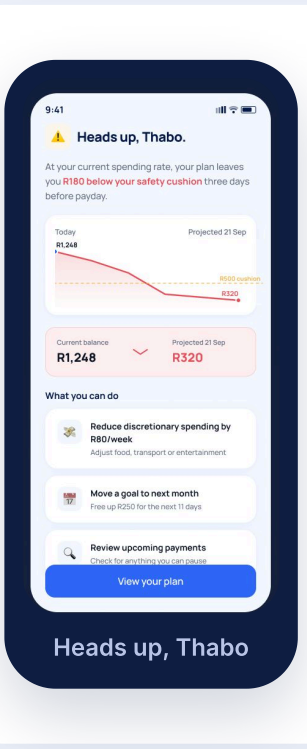
4 · Start with context, not compliance

DECISION: Lightweight questions about employment stage, income and priorities replace one dense KYC screen.

WHY: A new hire, someone on probation and someone months into a role may earn the same but need different support.

REJECTED: KYC-first onboarding. It tells the bank who the customer is, not what transition they're navigating.





5 · Warn before the buffer breaks

DECISION: RISE warns when an action is likely to reduce the buffer, showing what happens next and how to protect it.

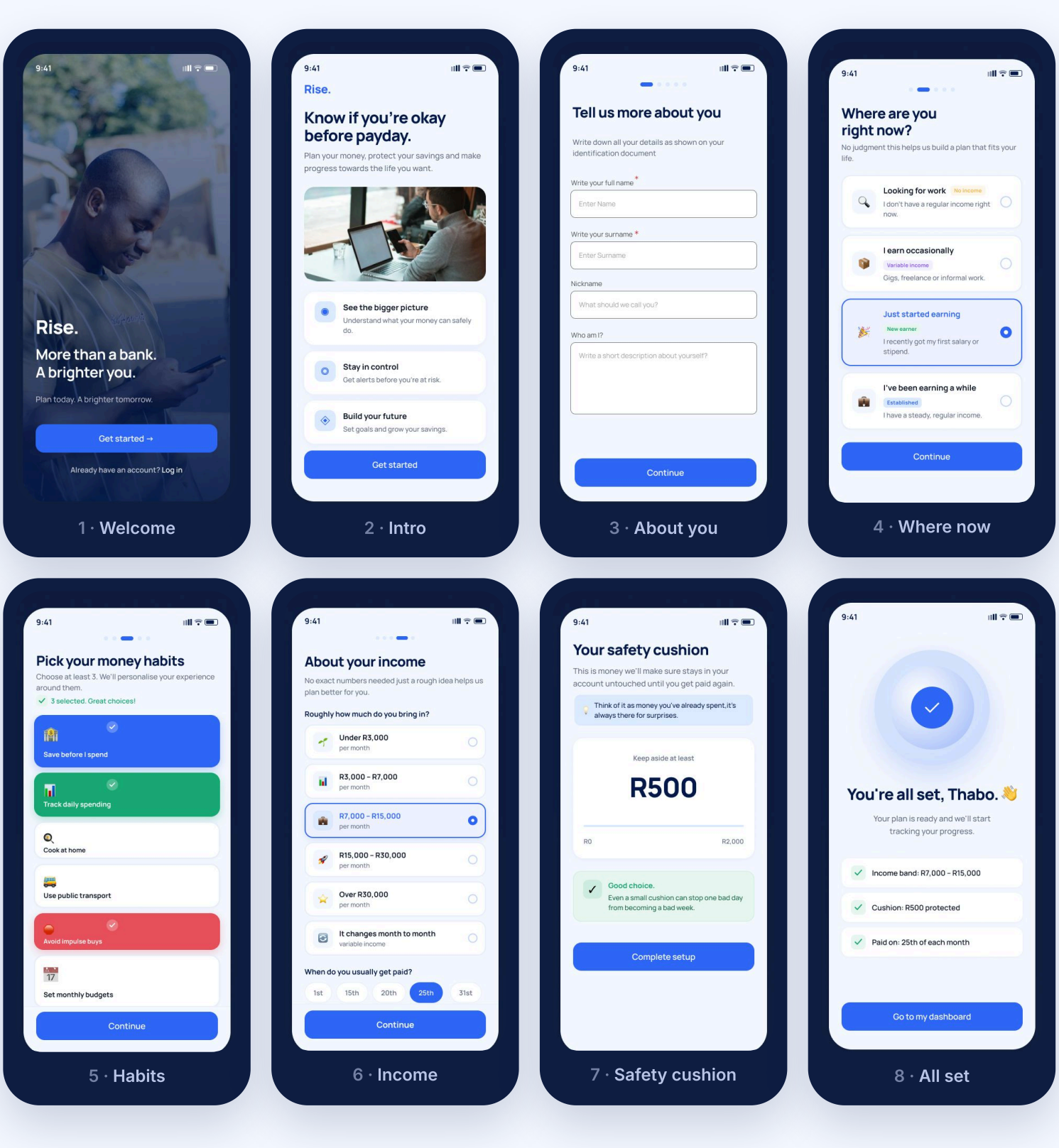
WHY: It turns an alert into a decision-support moment using the user's own context.

REJECTED: A fixed-threshold alert that reacts too late and ignores upcoming obligations.

The full screens

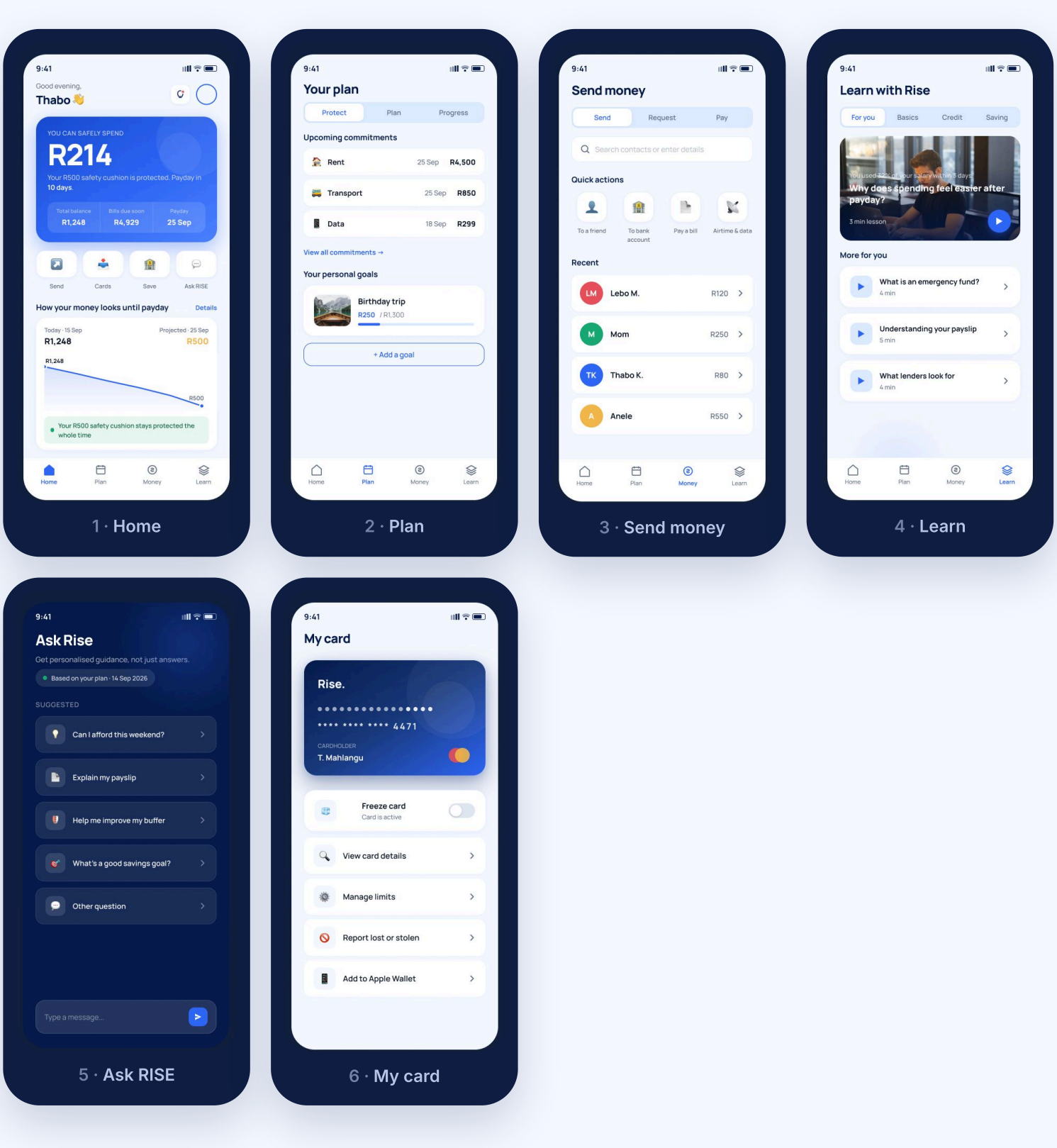
Onboarding

Context first: who Thabo is and what he's navigating, before any compliance.



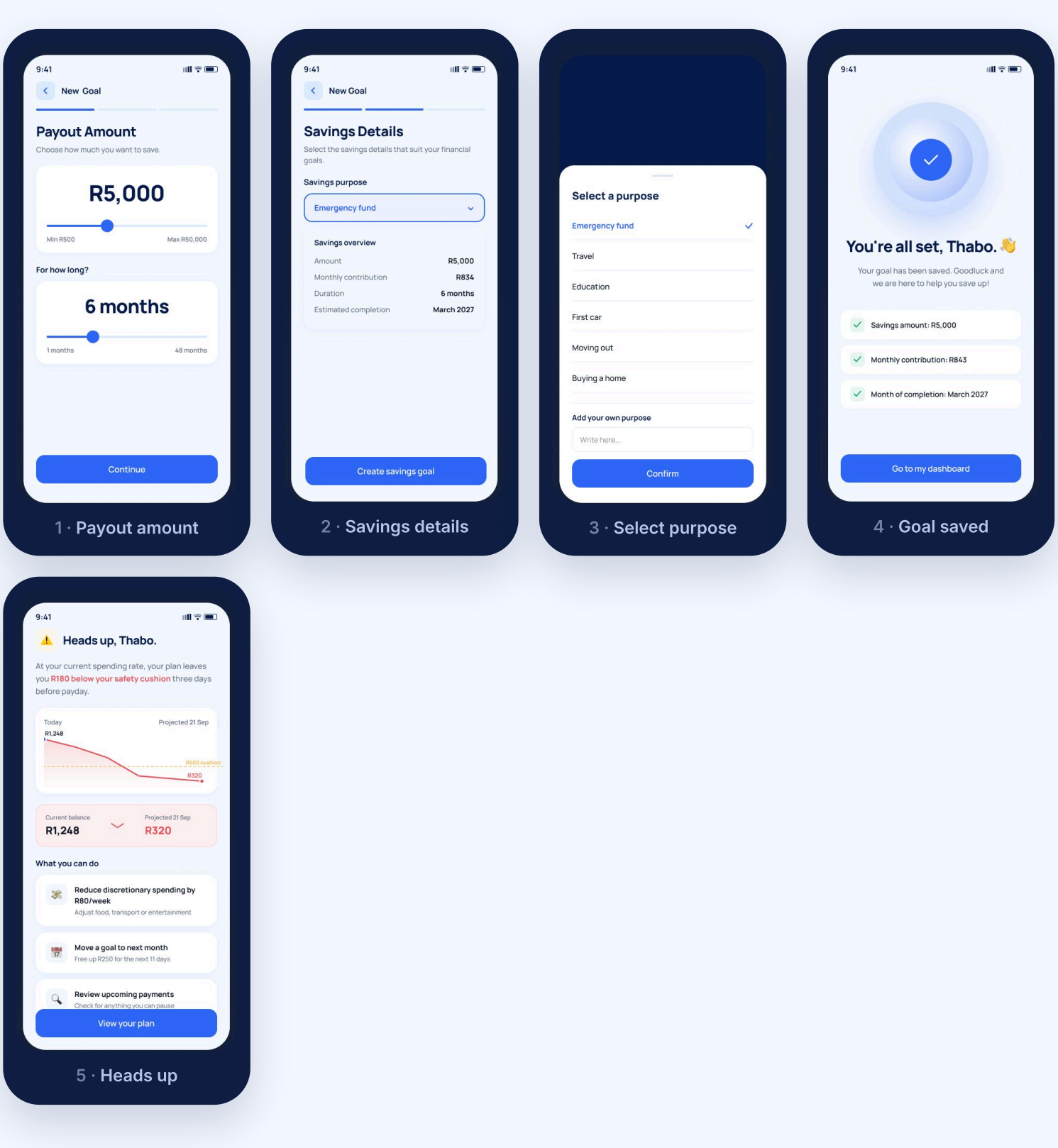
Core app

Safe-to-spend, plan, send, learn, ask and card in one calm shell.



Goals and warnings

Saving goals and the predictive buffer warning.



CHAPTER 07 OF 08

07 Success & impact

07 · SUCCESS & IMPACT

Success is a safety net that survives the month, not an account that gets opened.

PRIMARY MEASURE

Buffer > R0

Whether a safety net survived the month. It directly tests whether the design interrupted the loop.

1. **Secondary: app opens on payday**
   Shows a habit forming, not that anyone is better off.
1. **Rejected: sign-up rate**
   Easy to inflate with a marketing push.

Intended impact (to validate)

1. **Money left over**
   Thabo ends the month with something in his Buffer.
2. **Fewer surprises**
   Upcoming deductions are visible before they land.
3. **Help sooner**
   Questions get asked early instead of avoided out of shame.

> North star: does Thabo still have something in his Buffer the day before his next payslip lands?

Status: design exploration, not built or shipped, so there are no usage results yet. These measures define what impact would look like.

CHAPTER 08 OF 08

08 Lessons learned & next steps

08 · LESSONS LEARNED & NEXT STEPS

What I'd carry forward, and what comes next.

1. **Name the loop first**
   Seeing the monthly loop showed me the one point a product could actually change.
2. **Reject the convention on purpose**
   Naming what each decision replaces made the trade-offs easy to defend.
3. **Be honest about evidence**
   Secondary research and a composite persona are a starting point, so I said so and planned the test.

Next steps

1. **01 Test with real first-job earners**
   Check that the Buffer, predictive warning and Ask RISE behave as intended outside a prototype.
2. **02 Stress-test irregular income**
   Everything assumes a predictable payday. Gig and informal income must hold up when the day moves.
3. **03 Measure what matters**
   The real test is whether something is left in the Buffer the day before the next payslip.

Thank you for reading my case study

Hope you enjoyed it. 📈

Check my buffer

Buffer status: R500 protected. Mood: grateful. 😄

Stanslous Nhau · UX Designer · Johannesburg, South Africa

RISE was a self-directed exploration of what real financial support looks like in the first few months after a first paycheck, built from research, not assumption. Persona and quotes are illustrative composites.